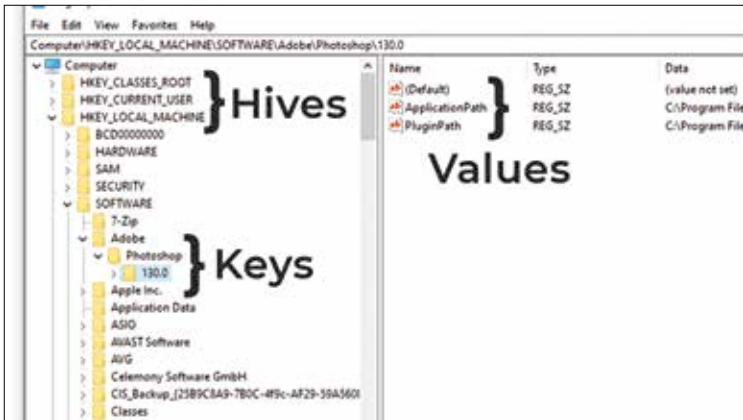




Hives, keys and values

and third-party applications. The registry also allows you to access counters for system performance profiling.

The registry contains two basic elements: Keys and Values. Then there is also the concept of Hives. We'll be exploring these in this chapter.

Registry Keys

Each key can have subkeys, which can contain further subkeys, and so on. Registry keys are similar to folders in that they can contain values as well as subkeys. Keys are addressed using a syntax similar to that of Windows path names, with backslashes used to signify hierarchy levels. Each subkey must have a name, which must be a non-empty string that does not contain any backslashes or null characters and is case insensitive.

Only a known root key handle (which is anonymous but whose effective value is a constant numeric handle) that is mapped to the content of a registry key preloaded by the kernel from a stored "hive," or to the content of a subkey within another root key, or mapped to a registered service or DLL that provides access to its contained subkeys and values can access the registry key hierarchy.

HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\Software\Microsoft\Windows refers to the subkey "Windows" of the subkey "Microsoft" of the subkey "Software" of the HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE root key.

There are seven predefined root keys:

- HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE or HKLM